

Interview 1, Sara, 26, Freelance On-Site Engineer

Sara works for several clients across Dublin, doing hardware installs and IT support. She typically has gaps between jobs and needs somewhere to sit, charge her laptop, and occasionally take calls.

What does a typical day look like for you?

It depends, honestly. I might have a morning job in the docklands, then nothing until 2 pm somewhere else, so I'm just killing time. I always have my bulky bag and laptop, so I can't really squeeze into a tiny pub corner. I usually end up in a coffee shop such as Insomnia or Costa but it's a gamble. Sometimes they're packed, no plugs, or the wifi is so bad I can't even check emails. Sometimes I just walk around for twenty minutes looking for a spot before giving up.

What do you need to get done during those gaps?

Mostly just admin stuff. Invoicing, emails, or writing up a quick report. Nothing crazy, but I need the connection to be solid. And I always need to charge up. My laptop runs all day on-site so by noon everything is dying. Sockets are actually more important to me than anything else. I can use my hotspot for wifi, but I can't charge my laptop off it. I've started doing some training videos too, but I need decent wifi for that.

How do you currently decide where to go?

To be honest, I just go to places I know and hope for the best like Insomnia or a calm Pub. Or I walk around until I see somewhere quiet. Google Maps doesn't really help with the useful stuff, like if there's actually space, if they'll kick you out after 20 minutes, or if the wifi even works. I've asked other freelancers, but no one seems to have a go to place or a preferred chain.

Have you ever turned up somewhere and it didn't work out?

All the time. Last week I sat down and the wifi was dead, the barista said it had been down all morning. I ended up using my hotspot again. It's such a waste. I'd much rather be somewhere comfortable where I can actually spread out. And there's nothing worse than getting settled with a coffee and realizing there isn't a single plug anywhere near you.

Do you notice a difference in available places across the city?

Some areas have loads of places made for laptop work. Great wifi and all, and you can stay for hours without getting the famous "you're not consuming" side eye. Other areas are much tougher. You get these lovely old-school pubs that just aren't set up for it. Or if you're near an estate, your only choice is a fast food joint. I know which parts of town are easy now, but I'm not always in those parts.

How much do you factor in the environment or 'vibe' of a place?

Yeah, I do. More than I should have to, really. I definitely notice when I'm the only woman in the room. It's not usually anything bad, just a vibe. Some of those chic, bohemian-style cafés can

feel a bit unwelcoming. You sit down and feel like people are clocking you, like you don't quite belong. I don't really want to deal with that after a long morning of manual work.

Can you give an example of that kind of moment?

There's this one spot near Temple Bar. I walked in, and it was just fifteen guys in hoods staring at screens. I sat down, and within minutes, someone asked if I was waiting for someone. It wasn't meant, it just felt like an assumption. I didn't go back. I ended up going to a worse spot just because I felt more comfortable there.

Does that factor into how you choose a place?

I do now, yeah. Especially if I'm in work gear, as this invites people to strike up a conversation with me. I naturally go towards places that feel mixed, the people, the staff, the whole vibe. Places where everyone feels different. I've noticed that cafés where I find a woman behind the counter just feel easier to be in. Maybe it's just me, but it's a real factor in where I choose to go. Honestly? Definitely. I'd trust that more than just 'vibes' because vibes can be wrong. You can go somewhere that looks fine until something happens. But if a place makes an effort to say 'we're a welcoming space' that matters. It makes me feel more confident going somewhere new, especially when I'm on my own.

What would make these gaps feel more productive?

Just knowing ahead of time that there's enough space, plugs, and decent wifi. I don't need anything fancy, I just need it to work. Ideally, I could take a quick call without people staring at me. And like I said, somewhere where it just feels normal to be a woman. That shouldn't be too much to ask.

What would your ideal booking experience look like?

Something fast. I don't want to be planning this the night before. If I finish a job and have two hours to kill, I want to see what's nearby and just go. Five minutes tops.

Is price a factor?

A bit. I'm not paying full coworking prices for a two-hour gap. But if it's a few quid and I know it's reliable and comfortable? Yeah, I'd pay that over wasting time somewhere useless.

Interview 2, Emma, 22, Computer Science Student & Part-Time Contractor

Emma is in her final year and does contract work for a few hours a week. She studies mostly in cafes because he finds home too distracting. He doesn't have a regular spot.

How do you typically structure your day for work or study?

It depends if I have classes. On my off-days, I'll get up, eat, and head out. I can't focus at home with two flatmates around. There's always something going on. The library is okay when you're not roaming around time and time again, but I hate the 'no food' thing, and I stay for ages, so I need coffee and snacks. Cafés are perfect for that, but finding a good one is a total lottery.

What makes a good versus a bad café session?

A good day is when I sit down, the wifi just works, there's a plug, and nobody's hovering over me to order more coffee every twenty minutes. I can get four or five hours of real work done like that. A bad day is just a constant stream of distractions. The wifi drops, my battery dies, the music is blasting, or the place gets super hectic. I've had days when I had to move cafés three times.

How does contract work change your needs?

Yeah, for sure. For studying, a bit of background noise is fine. But for contract work, I really need to lock in. And client calls are so awkward in a loud café. I've had to stand outside, which is just embarrassing. I even tried a call on a bus once, but it was a total disaster.

How do you discover new places?

Mostly just asking other students. We have a group chat where people share tips, but it's not always right. I usually just stick to the few places I know. Searching online doesn't tell you the important stuff.

What's your relationship with the library?

I use it sometimes, especially for exams. It closes at 9 pm, and I usually get into a good flow late at night. Plus, the Wi-Fi can be really slow with large files. It's also just very strict. No food, total silence... cafés just feel more human.

Have you ever tried a coworking space?

Once, with a free pass. It was amazing, loads of space, fast wifi, and even extra monitors. I got more done that day than in a whole week. But it's way too expensive for a student, and they offer no student plans that I can consider, budget-wise. It kind of spoiled me, though; now cafés feel like a bit of a compromise.

What information do you want to see before going somewhere?

Wifi speed is number one. Is it actually usable? Then, how busy is it right now? There's nothing worse than walking fifteen minutes and finding the place packed. Also, opening hours and plugs. I want to know I can plug in before I walk over.

Does working in the evenings cause any issues?

Yeah, tons of places close before 6 pm, which kills my evening. I've had to pack up mid-task and scramble to find somewhere else. In Dublin, there's really nowhere for people who want to work late.

How do you balance study versus contract work?

Mostly, but I'm trying to be smarter about it. On work days, I'll look for a quieter spot. On study days, I don't care as much. As the contract work becomes a bigger part of my income, I'll need to get more serious. I can't do client calls in noisy cafés forever.

What would make you use a spot-finding app consistently?

It has to be 100% accurate. I've been burned too many times by old info. If I show up and it's different from what the app said, I'm out. It needs to be fast, too. No filtering through a million things. Just show me what's nearby and how busy it is so I can decide in thirty seconds.

Would you pay to reserve a seat?

Maybe. For studying, probably not. I'd just use the info to find a good spot. But for work, especially with a deadline or a call? Definitely. Knowing I have a guaranteed spot is worth a few euros. I've definitely wasted more than that in time and stress when things don't work out.

What is often overlooked in the work-friendly space experience?

The stress. Nobody talks about the low-grade anxiety of not knowing where you're going to sit that day. It sounds small, but it drains your energy before you even start working. Anything that makes that easier would be a total game-changer.

Names were changed to accommodate the responders request.

Questions were drafted following a sentiment analysis process when exploring the following Reddit forums: [Forum 1](#), [Forum 2](#), [Forum 3](#), [Forum 4](#), [Forum 5](#)